

POLITICS OF ZILARGO



A SOURCEBOOK FOR THE WORLD OF EBERRON
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Homeland of the gnomes, Zilargo appears to be an idyllic, peaceful land. Lurking beneath the surface is a web of intrigue ready to ensnare an unsuspecting party of adventurers. The magic and riches of Zilargo are promising to the brave and foolhardy alike.

Unlike other nations in Khorvaire, Zilargo is not majority human. About three-fifths of its population are gnomes, with humans and dwarves forming significant minorities amongst the other two-fifths. While Kobolds have a significant presence in the mountains ringing Zilargo, they do not consider themselves subjects of the Zil state and are generally isolationist.

These demographics are reflected in every aspect of Zil life - while even the smallest village is built to accommodate medium-sized visitors, human visitors will nonetheless stick out from the crowd. The innate magic of the gnomes is important to Zil culture, with illusions simply being part of everyday life. Many gnomes are able to speak with small, burrowing creatures, a skill that is often overlooked in a gnome's method of intrigue. Visitors should watch the shadows for rodents that might be spying on them.

FAMILY MATTERS

Naturally sociable, gnomes value the bonds of kinship highly. This shows up in their names, where a gnome's "last name" is their clan, and their "middle name" is their family. Clans provide the general structure - a gnome and their family can jockey for position within the clan, but the clan succeeds or fails together. By contrast, family units demand intense loyalty, providing a set of connections every gnome can rely on regardless of their other schemes.

THE TRIUMVIRATE

When the humans ventured southward across the land, they came across a unique form of government - an oligarchy known as The Triumvirate, composed of a representative from each of Zilargo's three major cities. Each of these cities (and the surrounding areas) are governed by their own Council of Nine. To the uninformed, the Councils of Nine and the Triumvirate itself are democratically chosen, unique to Khorvaire. The simple truth is that these positions are entirely determined by the plots and schemes of the wealthy, deeply treasured both for their prestige and authority. Despite the large presence of non-gnomes in Zilargo, the Councils of Nine are populated solely by gnomes.

Responsible for the many laws of Zilargo, the Triumvirate wields almost absolute political power. However, the gnomes are keenly aware of the practical limits of this power, and frequently the threat of power is more than enough to accomplish what is necessary. A peculiarity of Zil politics is that while the elbowing and skullduggery between gnomish clans and families is intense, all agree and understand that the needs of the nation come first, and when real threats to national security emerge those rivalries must be put aside.

The grave exception to this national unity is the Aurum. While originally a dwarvish organization, the group grew significantly over the course of the war, promising stability and power in a shattered kingdom. While Eberron is home to a large number of secretive organizations, bigger fish like the Chamber or the Lords of Dust operate on a deeper level and on longer time scales than even gnomish schemes. By contrast, the personal greed of the Aurum strikes directly at the fundamental nature of Gnomish intrigue, bending the guardrails of safety.

For those of higher station in gnomish society, Aurum membership is something to be hidden rather than flaunted. Several members of the councils of nine are ranking members of the Aurum, but have thus far managed to conceal this status from the Trust.

THE TRUST

While the gnomes love their fun and games, the endless intrigue works because of the limits imposed by the Trust. There are only two rules - the national interest comes first, and no crime. The former rule comes in when gnomes try to leverage outside alliances for profit and gain. The second not only means the Trust maintain a monopoly on violence, but also ensures the intricate system of trust and debts in gnomish society continues to function.

The gnomish connection to Thelanis may play some role here, as the particular wording of debts and obligations is of utmost importance, with the letter of the law always coming before the spirit of it. An important part of growing up Zilargo is learning that fine line between creative interpretations of obligations and outright fraud. Furthermore, gnomes still understand that tit invites tat, and joyful fulfillment of obligations engenders bonds of friendship rather than distrust. Deception may be second nature, but friendships and family are treasures.

The Trust are a secret police in the sense that individual members work in secret, rather than their existence is a secret. Uninformed visitors from other lands may be unaware, but anyone with a passing understanding of Zil society knows that ambition is checked by the Trust.



History: Formed over two centuries ago as a way to preserve the scholarly focus of Korranberg college, the Trust today is a multinational intelligence agency that answers only to the Triumvirate. While the majority of the Trust's mission involves domestic affairs, gnome spies dot the five nations. In line with their national character, the gnomes didn't use this for direct military action. However, they were able to leverage their vast pool of intelligence to secede from Breland by declaring an "Alliance". Battered from the lengthy war, the Brelish were unable to devote resources to maintain sovereignty over a province-turned-ally.

Hierarchy: Today, the Trust maintains order through a finely layered set of agents and assets. On a basic level, the Trust rewards snitches and informants, who provide information via dead drops (leaving information in a previously-agreed upon location for the Trust agent to pick up) in exchange for financial compensation. More devoted assets may be asked to perform more complicated or important actions, such as deliver messages, in exchange for greater compensation.

The Trust employs two kinds of agents. *Ganos* ("eyes") manage webs of assets who provide information that can be transmitted home and processed by analysts and their superiors, who are known as *shalons* ("minds"). The shalons use this information to deploy the *valos* ("hands"), the trained thieves and assassins who enforce the law.

The trust has four secret languages, and the typical agent knows two to three, communicating with a given asset using only a single one of them. The Trust heavily "siloes" its operations, which is to say any given agent knows very little about the plans of other agents. The job of the home office is to coordinate agents in a way that avoids revealing their plans any more than necessary.

While ostensibly available to all well-resourced agencies, the Trust leverages "ghost" agents more than any other group. Such "ghost" agents are not incorporeal undead - rather, they are outfitted with a *ring of invisibility* and *ring of sustenance*, ensuring that they do not have to reveal themselves until the moment of their choosing. How many of these ghost agents is a mystery - the Brelish King's Dark Lanterns estimate that at least one ghost agent is positioned in each major city of Khorvaire, but the true number is up to the DM.

Methods: A common misconception (that the Trust actively promotes) is that the group is filled with lethal assassins. The truth is they rarely resort to violence, preferring to scare off potential lawbreakers. Masters of poisons, the Trust uses sub-lethal doses to communicate a message to a particularly stubborn target. However, if someone persists despite the warnings, the Trust will act before a crime is actually committed if they believe one will be.

Compared to the Code of Galifar, the Trust's system of law enforcement affords the accused few rights. At the same time, the Trust's consistent anti-corruption efforts, consistent attempts to de-escalate, and the general higher quality of life in Zilargo mean that on a pragmatic level, crime is much less common in the first place.

While working abroad as an intelligence agency rather than domestic law enforcement, the Trust's *corliganos* ("roving eyes") only take action when absolutely necessary. The Trust prefers to simply accumulate knowledge for use in future conflicts, staying as a "neutral" third party in the cold war the surviving nations are engaged in.

SAMPLE NPCs

Ranadala Josilyn Hebbardesh is a kindly old woman with leathery, olive skin and wispy gray hair. She commonly hosts travelers in her house for free. As a Trust asset, she regularly writes (encoded) letters documenting all suspicious behavior she's witnessed each week and leaves it on a local park bench to be picked up by her agent. She knows the name of every rodent on her block, each of whom constantly feed her information about what they've observed.

Tassi Til Harlian is a blue-haired gnome with an ugly birthmark on her left cheek. Naturally attracted to power, she's attached herself to the Riedran ambassador as a buxom blonde "local advisor" via a *Circlet of Human Perfection*. The Trust uncovered her attraction to power and has transformed her into an asset, paying her for regular updates.

Castar Canatar Korrian is a grey-skinned gnome with wild green hair. He spends his days as a local tinker, venturing out into the village marketplace to trade his curious inventions or perform home services. A licensed member of Cannith's tinker's guild, in secret he is a *gano* who is actually preoccupied with recruiting new assets and collecting information from his existing web.

Talina Talius Harlian is short even by gnomish standards, with neatly bundled brown hair atop her head. She spends her time perfecting her poison dosages via animal tests, disengaged from the social scene of Zilargo. As a *valo* for the Trust she acts with professionalism, preferring poisons that work silently rather than make a scene.

Sanadal Suvius Hebbardesh is a transman with curly orange hair and thin, feyish features. He has been trailing a single noble heir for two years now, watching and learning every move. While he sometimes wonders the reasons for this assignment, he has followed his instructions perfectly to keep the heir safe and out of too much trouble. This has required removing troublesome friends from the heir's life and rescuing the heir from self-created trouble at least once. Sanadal isn't entirely sure why the heir is so important - he's not close to the throne - but assumes that the *shalons* have a plan for the right time and the right place.

Torius Talius Harlian is a blond-haired and chocolate-skinned *shalon* for the Trust, concerned with the Riedran threat. About a decade ago while on a mission he made contact with the Kalashtar enclave in Sharn and learned about the Dreaming Dark. He has martialled resources towards uncovering the Dreaming Dark's plans, but has prioritized ensuring that the Dreaming Dark does not know the Trust knows about them. He has recently sent agents to Sarlona to directly infiltrate and investigate the Dreaming Dark's plans. Concerned about the Quori's ability to compromise the Trust from within, he may look to outside help to fix any number of issues.

RING OF SUSTENANCE

Ring, uncommon (requires attunement)

This ring automatically handles most biological functions for you. While wearing this ring, you do not need to eat, drink, or use the restroom. In addition, you only need to sleep for two hours to gain the benefits of a long rest.

KORRANBERG

Korranberg is the city of truth and knowledge, its library the best collection of knowledge outside of Argonessen. House Sivis calls Korranberg home, maintaining its largest enclave in the city. The Korranberg Chronicle is produced here, independently owned by the Jarell clan.

THE LIBRARY OF KORRANBERG

Founded by an eccentric and obsessive gnome, Dorius Alyre ir'Korran sought to create a large enough repository of information that he could ascend and take Aureon's place amongst the sovereigns. Despite Dorius' apparent failure to ascend to the divine, the project of a massive library was popular not just within the ir'Korran family, but all of Zilargo. Only the most stubborn secrets have eluded the Library's grasp, making it a resource or even patron for inquiring adventurers. The library maintains offices in every major city of Khorvaire, tasked with improving local connections.

Not only is the library important for its collection of books and other knowledge receptacles (most of which are stored in extradimensional locations), it has become the center of life in Korranberg. The library has eight colleges, each with their own specialty listed in the table below. Unlike the Twelve or the Arcane Congress, the Library is interested in more than just magical secrets.

College	Specialty
Aureon's Holt	Law and Oratory
Balinor's Horn	Natural Sciences
Blackdragon	Alchemy
Drystone	Engineering
Lyrris	Art and Literature
Morridan	Mathematics
Soladas	History
The Tabernacle	Religion and Philosophy

All citizens of Korranberg, regardless of if they are gnomes or not, are privileged with a free education at the college at the cost of four years of service. Many happily extend this service to entire careers, whether becoming professors, administrators, or any other number of positions that can be found at an institute of higher education.

Like everything else in Zilargo, the Library is enmeshed in intrigue and schemes of the gnomes. The title of high councilor (currently held by Alina Alrene ir'Korran) is reserved for a member of the ir'Korran clan, but the many descendants of Dorius constantly vie for the title. On a more basic level, while the colleges are well-to-do, resources are still fundamentally limited and are thus contested.

A lower stakes but very serious matter is the annual competition between the colleges, held during the Zarantyr break. Each college selects a team of nine individuals to compete for four weekends in a series of challenges. Positions on these teams are highly coveted, and are selected by the head of each school. Contestants spend the week preparing by trying to spy what the challenges might be and studying past years events. Drystone was on a twelve year winning streak until last year's upset to Balinor's Horn.

HOUSE SIVIS

House Sivis, the only clan of dragonmarked gnomes, bears the Mark of Scribing. Masters of the written word, the gnomes of Sivis are both emblematic of gnomish culture and stand apart. Internally, the house is full of constant schemes as members jockey for positions of authority. Externally, the house is detached from the affairs of Zilargo, despite accusations and conspiracy theories involving the house feeding information to the Trust. More than anything though, House Sivis represents the gnomish obsession with the written word, their chosen way to cope with their long lives.

Within Zilargo, House Sivis' Notaries Guild is more important than the Speaker's Guild. The legalistic culture of the gnomes frequently requires that every detail of a transaction is recorded, and the notaries guild provides.

House Sivis calls Korranberg home. The tower enclave is impressive, but The Labyrinth that lies below it is the true marvel. Alleged to date back to the earliest days of the gnomes, the Labyrinth is where all of House Sivis' secrets are stored. Jealously guarded and, unlike the public areas of Zilargo, sized for small creatures, the Labyrinth would be a herculean heist. Still, it periodically tempts both independent and state-sponsored thieves. None have succeeded.

THE KORRANBERG CHRONICLE

Based on the Bookbinder's Quarter, the Korranberg Chronicle is the finest journalistic outfit in Khorvaire. The proud work of the Jarell clan, while the Korranberg Chronicle was well-known prior to the war, it only became the paper of record through the persistent and insightful coverage of the hundred years of war. The dogged coverage of war crimes in particular has been instrumental to the Thronehold Tribunal's efforts at accountability in the post-treaty world.

SAMPLE NPCs

Lassius Lin Harlian is a doctoral candidate in Blackdragon college. His thesis is a new ingestible poison that makes the imbibers' memories susceptible to alteration. He sees it as a way to help people forget traumas, but more sinister applications certainly exist. He's had difficulties getting funding to purchase the necessary ingredients for more than a small proof of concept. The biggest is a rare flower that only blooms when at least four moons are full in the night sky and is only found in the Seawall Mountains. In addition to his thesis he's juggling TAing for his thesis advisor, being a barista, and unpaid secretary work from his advisor.

Gabriela is an eladrin from the Summer Court of Pylas Pyrial who has taken up residence at Korranberg College. A gifted diviner, she floats amongst the endless stacks of books, guided to tomes of prophetic import. Many mistake the bat that accompanies her for a familiar or fey spirit - it's actually just a bat she's made friends with. She occasionally seeks out adventuring types with cryptic warnings or quests.

Jandia Syrralan Jarell is a globe-trotting journalist for the Korranberg Chronicle. After spending the last century documenting the Last War from start to finish, she's moved to a senior editorial position. Fiercely passionate about her reporting, she's interested in any story that speaks truth to power. She's concerned about the status of one of her reporters who went dark a month ago chasing down an international crime syndicate and hasn't checked in since.

TROLANPORT

Trolanport is a capital city of canals and commerce. While Sharn may be the largest city in the continent, Trolanport nearly matches it for the sheer volume of economic activity. Not only have the gnomes set up a favorable port for goods from all over - Seren relics, Xen'drik treasures, Riedran fineries - but many dragonmarked houses have major enclaves, as Trolanport is the center for the elemental binding trade.

DRAGONMARKED HOUSES

The fundamental tension in Trolanport is between the four dominant gnome clans (the Clebdechers, the Lonadars, the Tarliachs, and the Trolans) and the dragonmarked houses. Each of the clans represents a diverse portfolio of economic interests, while the houses are specialized based on their mark. Furthermore, the clans utilize a complicated system of sharing ownership of businesses to split profits and decisionmaking via the trading of "stocks", a byzantine pile of paperwork that's unintelligible to outsiders.

While the houses have monopolized their industries elsewhere in Khorvaire, they have failed to extend that dominance to Trolanport. Some of this is due to natural gnomish ingenuity making up for the supernatural skills of dragonmarked members. More importantly is the gnomish talent for subterfuge presenting a challenge unlike anything else the houses have faced.

THE DOCKS

While canals and small ships fill the city, the key to Trolanport's rise was its docks. The Trolan clan are renowned shipbuilders and founded the city centuries ago, still maintaining a majority stake in the city's shipping business. They have cordial relationships with both the Clebdecher and Tarliach clans, who provide essential materials for their ships. The Clebdechers have a dominant stake in the city's livestock, textiles, and alchemy businesses. The Tarliachs control the farming and logging that goes on around the city, bringing the raw materials to be worked into ships.

Sailors visiting Trolanport know the gnomes do not tolerate the reckless brawling of Sharn's Cliffside district. Still, the gnomes freely encourage drunkenness and the indulgence of other vices as a way to acquire information and potential blackmail. The Trust is behind every front of organized crime on the docks, carefully entrapping shady figures and protecting the citizens of the city.

The hottest business at the docks now is Sarlonan art. The leading socialites of Trolanport have declared that Tashana shifter art is "in", much to the chagrin of the Riedran traders who are now "out". The Inspired Lords of Riedra see their Tashana Tundra neighbors to the north as uncivilized at best, and cannot fathom why the refined gnomes would showcase such "savage" art during the weekly galas.

For their part, the gnomes delight in learning about foreign cultures and treat them with great respect. The great competition now is to get actual shifters from the Tundra to a gala and interact with them, but so far the gnomes have run into trouble making this happen. Many suspect Riedran interference, and are considering interfering back if their desires are still frustrated.

ELEMENTAL BINDING

Elemental Binding is a complicated process with results that define modern Khorvaire. The mighty lightning rail and airships attract plenty of attention, but smaller elemental-bound items are just beginning to enter the market.

Binding an elemental into an item is a complicated process. First, khyber shards of appropriate quality must be acquired. Second, an alchemical treatment must be applied to the shard to enhance its "carrying capacity" and to enable the power of the bound spirit to be harnessed. Third, the shard must be enchanted with proper conduits for its power. Fourth, the shard must be installed in an appropriate item, which requires a different set of arcane principles in the construction of the item. Finally, the power of an item may require siberys shards tuned to an appropriate dragonmark to be commercially viable.

Of these five steps, the Dragonmarked Houses are only included in the last two. The Lonadar clan has the strongest ties to the mountain clans that own Khyber shards for the first step, who then sell them to the Clebdecher clan for the second alchemical step. The Lonadar clan then buys the alchemically-treated shards and enchants them. Cannith does the majority of the work for the fourth step, but Lonadar artificers still consult on new item designs. The fifth step is the only one entirely under the control of the houses, where Cannith and the appropriate and relevant house work together to attune the Siberys shards.

The dragonmarked houses have attempted to bypass the Zil's bottleneck on elemental binding, but the gnomes have thus far kept their secrets. Ironically, while the gnomes claim their ingenuity led to the key abjuration and alchemical breakthroughs responsible for modern elemental binding, the truth is the gnomes themselves stole the abjuration rituals from the Sulatar drow of Xen'drik. To be fair, the gnomes in conjunction with the houses have dramatically improved upon Sulatar techniques, but the fundamental breakthrough was pirated from the Sulatar. Those who know this secret history fear that one day, the Sulatar will have revenge.

SAMPLE NPCs

Elymar Ilian Clebdecher, a moderately wealthy head of family, is looking to expand his elemental binding business in the new smaller, personal items business. He has funded expeditions to areas naturally rich in mephits and other minor elementals, hoping to find a cheaper method than calling them directly from other planes. His biggest problem has been the Power of Purity, an organization that believes binding elementals is cruel and seek to abolish the practice.

Lysse Alysse Lonadar is one of the most powerful women in Zilargo who chooses to moonlight as a gondolier. She prefers to use her guise as an old woman to attract pity, framing herself as a poor old gnome working a traditional job. Visitors who buy into her tale may find themselves on a wild quest around the city that is much more elaborate than they anticipated. Those who are unfriendly face worse.

Leopold Maximus Tarliach is a producer affiliated with a major theatre in Trolanport, *The Dashing Swordsman*. Bored with his life, he's concocted a scheme - oversell the profits on his next show, then put together the worst play, director, and actors possible to ensure it crashes and burns so he doesn't have to pay out. He's looking for the right group of gullible idiots to star in his new show - what could go right?

ZOLANBERG

The smallest of the three cities of Zilargo, Zolanberg is best known for its mines. While not as rich as the entire expanse of the Mror Holds, the mines of Zolanberg are a strategic asset to the nation. The mines come with plenty of trouble, not just from the environmental impact of mining but also the native kobolds that live in the Seawall Mountains.

MINING

Zolanberg's mines are constantly expanding as they extract the mineral wealth of the Seawall Mountains. While Zolanberg and its immediate area are mined out, the city claims dominion over the entire mountain range, and miners bring their findings to the city to engage in trade with the wider world.

Centuries ago the city brought in dwarves from the Mror Holds as consultants, and in the time since a sizeable dwarf population has established itself. While the dwarves lack political power, they have a stable economic influence.

Key to the actual process of mining is access to other natural resources, namely timber and water. While the Lyrris clan has the largest stake in the region's Khyber shard mines, and the Zolan clan has made a name for itself with its silver mines, both must negotiate with the other, as the Lyrris clan holds many of the local water rights while the Zolan clan has a majority of the logging rights. The incomplete nature of each clan's dominance means they must work together even as they scheme against each other.

A secondary effect of the mining in the Seawall Mountains is the downstream effects. The Adredar clan populates many of the Zil villages at the foot of the mountains and is heavily invested in agriculture. Mining runoff is a constant problem, as bigger and bolder mines cause more and more pollution. Thus far the problem has kept to a matter of local politics, with the agricultural villages threatening to raise food prices or outright boycott Zolanberg's markets if conditions don't improve, but escalating tensions may involve the Trust.

DRAGONMARKED HOUSES

Only three (non-Sivis) houses have a major presence in Zolanberg - Orien, Kundarak, and Tharashk. The somewhat isolated nature of the city, plus the insular nature of the gnomes, makes it difficult for the others to make much profit in Zolanberg, even if they keep small enclaves.

Orien's presence is straightforward, operating the lightning rail that keep the markets of Zolanberg supplied. The heirs of passage have lobbied the city's Council of Nine hard to ensure no airship docking tower is built.

Kundarak's role in Zolanberg is its security services, keeping one of the largest vaults in Khorvaire in the city. Similar to the rest of Zilargo, Kundarak's financial offerings lack the popularity in the rest of Khorvaire. Most citizens prefer financing from the Nezelech and Lyrris clans, with only outsiders preferring Kundarak.

House Tharashk has been trying to edge their way into Zolanberg's economy, offering themselves as prospectors. The gnomish clans, insular as they are, are reluctant to let the house in on their riches. An adventuring party escorting a Tharashk prospector to a new Khyber shard mine might be just what the house needs to prove its value.

THE HAKA'JHAR

The Haka'jhar nation of kobolds calls the Seawall mountains home. Classed as "Irvhir" kobolds, they claim to have been formed directly from the blood of Khyber. Intensely xenophobic, the kobolds have failed to hold back the steadily encroaching gnomish mines. Still, the Haka'jhar are a persistent threat, both to personal safety and the continued economic productivity of the Zil mines.

Since the end of the Last War there are reports of Kobold activity farther from the Seawall mountains, as if the kobolds have tunnels extending out into Zilargo proper. Despite this, no magic has been able to find these tunnels, if they do exist at all. Adventurers and other security forces more familiar with the kobolds report that they have an unusual amount of sorcerers, and scholars have theorized that their connection to the Dragon Below and thus the prophecy may be more than myth. Either the Lords of Dust or the draconic Chamber may be manipulating the kobolds to some end - but what?

CYRAN REFUGEES

While New Cyre and Sharn are well-known as the home of Cyran refugees, a lesser known fact is that the gnomes of Zilargo were especially hospitable. While the first refugees were from those who fled West out of South Cyre (modern Darguun), the communities swelled after the Day of Mourning. The refugees in Zolanberg don't hold any political power, but their community is looked after with kindness by the Council of Nine. The community leader is Zinat Harun, an elderly woman with tanned, leathery skin who came with the original refugees decades ago from South Cyre.

SAMPLE NPCs

Alina Lorridan ir'Lyrris, also known as the "Daughter of Khyber", is a wealthy socialite and the unusually young head of the Lyrris clan, barely over sixty years of age. Her rise has been downright meteoric - in the past decade she has become the head of the clan, discovered the largest and richest khyber shard mine to date, and worked her way up the Aurum to the secretive Shadow Council. On the surface level, her secret position within the Aurum is a grave threat to Zolanberg, but rumors about consorting with the forces of Khyber could pose an even more dire threat.

Cassia Del Adredar has channeled her connection to the primal world into becoming a druid to defend her clan's homes at the foothills of the Seawall Mountains. Conditions have noticeably worsened the past decade as the Khyber shard trade has picked up, not only creating pollution but drawing the attention of fiends and aberrations. Drawing upon her stronger-than-normal fey connection, Cassia has made alliances with pixies and other minor fey to disrupt Lyrris operations and preserve the environment.

Nupwaggle is a Haka'jhar kobold sorcerer who is using illusion magic to infiltrate Zolanberg. Clever even by kobold standards, "Illian Torralyn Zolan" has the proverbial ear of multiple members of the Council of Nine. He seeks to bait the gnomes into overextending into a devastating defeat to the Kobold's trap-filled tunnels. His patience has been tested multiple times as the gnomes win battle after battle against the kobolds, pushing his people to retreat to deeper and more dangerous territory. He believes his patience will be rewarded and he can win the war, but he fears the final cost.

PYLAS PYRIAL

Similar to many of the races of Eberron, the origins of the gnomes is shrouded in mythology. Ten thousand years ago, the early Dhakaani record facing off against vicious "jungle rats", masters of deceptive defenses. What happened in the intervening years is unclear - one story tells of a gnomish king who made a pact with a fey lord, the gnomes joining the Summer Council of Pylas Pyrial. If such a king existed, his or her name has been lost to history. Another story says there was no pact and no king - instead, a collective of gnomish heroes tricked their way onto the court, impressing the fey lords with their wit and skill.

Whatever the story, a collective of gnomes with extended lifespans have lived amongst the eladrin and other fey of Pylas Pyrial for a great length of time and compose a portion of the ruling Summer Court. These fey gnomes have always had cordial ties with the ordinary gnomes of Zilargo, but this relationship has blossomed into an alliance since the Day of Mourning, when the feyspire was stranded on the Material.

While the relationship is still fresh, the Triumvirate have sent dozens of diplomatic staff to the feyspire to learn arcane and other secrets.

DRAGONROOST

Dragonroost is the largest town in the otherwise docile, rolling plains of northern Zilargo. While the occasional Dhakaani ruin dots the countryside, the gnomish resistance prevented them from heavily settling the area. The area was amongst the first to collapse from the Xoriat invasion, with gnomes sweeping in after retreating Dhakaani forces to devour the knowledge left behind.

Boasting the largest human population of any city in Zilargo besides Trolanport, Dragonroost is a cosmopolitan trading hub. The city boasts two critical advantages - it's where the headwaters coming down from the Howling Peaks turn into the Oskilor River down into Glamer Bay, and a local Thelanian manifest zone keeps beautiful and rare flowers blooming all year long. While the Lightning Rail does not pass through the city, Orien maintains plenty of caravans that take a pit stop on their way down to Trolanport.

The city is named after the large quantity of "domesticated" faerie dragons that roost in the area. The faerie dragons play along with the gnomish games of wit, acting as spies and messengers in exchange for baubles and morsels. Visitors quickly learn not to anger the creatures.

Lacking the size or stature to gain representation in the Triumvirate, Dragonroost is ruled by a council of three clans - the Davandis, the Nezzelechs, and the Santiars.

Today, the city is managing an influx of Cyran refugees who weren't comfortable with the constant reminder of loss that is New Cyre. As with Zolanberg, the gnomes have been more than hospitable, but not all the refugees have adapted to the rules of Zilargo. The Trust has done its best to keep things in line, but not every refugee is comfortable with the discreet and preemptive justice enacted by the shadowy organization.

LOCAL POLITICS

Outside the bustling cities of Zilargo, life is still full of intrigue, but of the gentler and kinder type. Arguments over the precise location of a fence post or the ownership of a particular ram are common, but to outsiders the gnomes are warm and welcoming. Every gnomish village is constructed with medium-sized visitors in mind, making travel through Zilargo a comforting experience. In fact, House Ghallanda has very few formal enclaves, and the Gnomish tendency to reject foreign influence means few hostels bother with Ghallanda accreditation.

The forests of Zilargo are free of dangerous beasts, long since removed by the city states and other adventurers. Even as the Last War raged on, Zilargo remained safe and secure, so unlike the five nations there was no opportunity for a resurgence of creatures that lurk and hunt in the dark. The biggest threat is the fey, whom the gnomes do not generally consider a threat but can cause trouble for adventurers. The fey are especially fond of humbling the arrogant, meaning that any traveling party of adventurers is almost certainly a target for Thelanian tricks and games.

NOBILITY

When Galifar swept across southern Khorvaire, conquering what is modern Breland, the gnomes offered to join the new nation on the condition they would retain most of their autonomy, only paying taxes to the Brelish governorship. When Wroann seceded in 892 YK, those taxes went to the freshly independent Brelish crown. In 962 YK, Zilargo declared itself an ally of Breland - no longer paying taxes or other forms of dues, but continuing in trade relations and material support of Breland's war effort.

In the early days of Galifar the gnomes decided to mimic the stylings of the human nobles with the *ir'* prefix. In Zilargo, a gnome may use the prefix if and only if they sit on a Council of Nine. As such, the title is much rarer and not tied to heredity, unlike the rest of Khorvaire.

Outside of the major cities, the semi-democratic nature of gnomish communities makes landed titles irrelevant.

SAMPLE NPCs

Alian Alyre Dalian is a gnomish villager who has a very particular problem - a dire goose has been terrorizing his village. The goose is implacable, stealing items and scaring children. The dire goose is nearly as large as an adult gnome, is completely fearless, and apparently immune to illusions.

Nicholas Angel, a Cyran refugee who's moved to the Zil countryside, is a new resident of the town of Reven near the Brelish border. The town has won the "Village of the Year" award for the past twenty years. A former special operative for the Cyran crown, Nicholas is suspicious of what secrets lurk in this hamlet.

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